

Avoiding Online and Phone Scams!

- **Speaker:** David Messerschmitt (Retired UC Berkeley faculty member specializing in computer and communication engineering; resident of a senior community in San Mateo).
- **Date:** May 2026
- **Context:** This is an updated and refreshed talk designed to build "Internet smarts" analogous to traditional "street smarts."

1. The Growing Threat Profile & Enablers

Impact of Connectivity

Technology impacts our lives in both positive and negative ways:

- **Automobile:** Kills 40,000 people annually in the United States.
- **Connectivity (Mail, phone, internet, cellular):** Opens up multiple new pathways for con artists and highly sophisticated scams.

It is up to us to minimize and mitigate the negative.

Technological Enablers

- **Universal Reach:** Mail, telephone calls, text messages, and emails can originate cheaply from anywhere in the world (e.g., Asia or Eastern Europe) to target anyone.
- **Industrial Scale Operations:** Modern operations are run as large-scale industrial complexes (such as the "Dongmei Zone" situated between Myanmar and Thailand) utilizing massive racks of automated cell phones. These entities frequently involve human trafficking networks.
- **Hyper-Realistic Falsification:** Current technologies allow anyone, anywhere, to convincingly portray themselves as someone or something else via speech, audio, video, emails, texts, and websites.
- **Deepfakes:** Double-blind experiments reveal that humans cannot reliably detect AI-generated pictures or videos. Furthermore, scammers only require a brief 30-second audio sample to clone a realistic rendering of someone's voice for

telephone fraud.

- **Targeting Seniors:** Scammers aggressively target older adults because they are perceived as more affluent.

Economic Trends (FBI Internet Crime Report 2025 Data)

Note: These statistics strictly reflect reported losses via the Internet Crime Complaint Center (IC3) and do not account for unreported events or fraud committed solely through physical mail or telephone networks.

- Total reported digital fraud losses reached **\$20.877 billion** by 2025 (surging dramatically from \$17.8 million in 2001, \$1.0 billion in 2015, \$10.3 billion in 2022, and \$16.6 billion in 2024).
- Overall financial losses are climbing at roughly **40% per year**.
- Financial fraud losses for individuals over the age of 60 are rising even faster—exploding at **60% per year**.

2. Psychological Manipulation Strategy: How Scams Catch Smart People

Con artists use advanced behavioral triggers to bypass logical technical filters:

- **Convincing Imitations:** Utilizing exact copies of recognizable branding, graphics, and tones.
- **Personalization:** Tailoring specific details about the target to create context and plausibility.
- **Anxiety & Urgency:** Inducing sudden fear of terrible consequences (e.g., legal or financial ruin) to strip away the victim's window for secondary evaluation. Immediacy intentionally stops you from thinking.

3. Core Universal Red Flags

Be deeply suspicious if an interaction exhibits any of the following characteristics:

- **Demands Immediate Action:** The scammer states you must act instantly to avoid legal trouble, penalties, or service cancellation.**The 24-Hour Rule:** No legitimate company or government agency ever demands immediate, high-pressure action without notice—period.

- **Requests Confidential Information:** Direct prompts asking you to hand over keys, files, or personal verification parameters.
- **Irreversible Payment Demands:** Requests to send money via anonymous, untraceable methods such as cash, gift cards, international wire transfers, or cryptocurrency.
- **Overly Friendly Strangers:** Unsolicited, overly personal approaches that frequently signal the launch of an intricate confidence game (such as a romance or fraudulent investment scam).
- **"Too Good to be True" Structures:** Investment or sweepstakes opportunities promising unrealistic payouts. According to the FBI, this represents the single largest category of monetary loss for seniors.

4. The "Scam Shield" Defensive Framework

The Core Principle: A Question of Control

- **Out of Control (The Marionette / Puppet on Strings Metaphor):** An unknown, remote puppeteer is pulling your strings—telling you where to go, what to look up, and what to do. It does not matter if the communication looks completely authentic.
- **In Control (The Anchor / Ship's Wheel Metaphor):** You determine the parameters of the interaction, halting artificial momentum and grounding yourself.

Step-by-Step Defense Action Plan

1. **Recognition Phase:** Realize that action is being demanded of you through an unexpected, unsolicited channel (USPS mail, a call, text, email, web ad, or an aggressive computer pop-up window). Always think back to exactly how the interaction started.
2. **Exit the Stage:** Refuse to play the role of the puppet. Instantly drop the session—hang up the phone, delete the message, close the window, or ignore the prompt. If you disengage immediately, you cannot be scammed.
3. **Establish Control on Your Own Terms:** If the context of the message seemed plausible and you want to verify it, independently seek out an equivalent interaction strictly on your own terms.

How to Safely Acquire Corporate/Government Contact Numbers

- **DO:** Pull numbers from verified physical assets inside your house (e.g., the back of a plastic credit card, a past paper billing statement, or trusted official printed directories).
- **DO:** Pull details directly from your own device's saved contact list.
- **DO:** Manually type a company's exact, verified URL address directly into your web browser.
- **DO (With Extreme Caution):** Use standard organic search results.
- **NEVER:** Use phone numbers, links, or callback extensions provided inside an unsolicited alert or suspicious message.
- **NEVER:** Trust or call phone numbers displayed on paid search advertisements (such as Google or Facebook Ads).

5. Case Study Examples

Tech Support / Customer Service Malvertising Traps

- **The Vulnerability:** Fraudsters buy paid placement space at the absolute top of search engine results, displaying fake hotlines and spoofed support URLs using legitimate brand imagery.
- **Real-World Incident Encountered:** Relying on an official-looking support number pulled from a deceptive Google Ad.

Fabricated Government or Legal Threats

- **The Vulnerability:** Scammers use intimidation tactics to demand money or sensitive verification codes under the guise of official authority.
- **Real-World Incident Encountered:** Receiving an urgent threat of immediate arrest for a fabricated "failure to appear for jury duty."

Grandparent / Relative in Distress Scams

- **The Vulnerability:** Emergency calls explicitly engineered to induce panic, claiming a loved one or grandchild is in immediate danger or locked in a county jail detention center needing bail money. These are increasingly amplified by AI voice

cloning.

- **Defensive Practice Plan:**

1. Set up and verify a secret family safeword.
2. Ask highly specific, leading questions about family history that an outsider or automated system could not answer.
3. Hang up the line, look up the relative's true personal phone number independently, and call them back directly.

The "Mystery Mailbox" & Postcard Traps

- **The Vulnerability:** Receiving physical "Final Notice — Action Required" cards or bright pink vehicle service plan alerts inside your actual mailbox demanding an immediate response via phone.

Deceptive Browser Pop-ups

- **The Vulnerability:** A full-screen browser window locks up with flashing red warnings claiming: *"WARNING! YOUR COMPUTER MAY BE INFECTED!"*
- **The Threat:** San Mateo Police report that this is currently the most successful scam targeting older adults. Calling the line allows bad actors to trick you into granting them complete remote access to download malware or harvest data from your computer.

"Pig Butchering" Text Messages

- **The Vulnerability:** A seemingly accidental "wrong number" text message arrives (*"Hello... Aren't you Kevin? Sorry I think I added the wrong person"*). When you respond politely, the scammer uses warm social engineering techniques to spark a long-term conversation (*"I see you as a kind person, acquaintance is fate, where are you from?"*).
- **The Threat:** This is the beginning of an elaborate confidence game explicitly designed to lure you into a fake commodity or crypto investment pipeline. Even answering a simple "wrong number" text signals to their automated systems that your phone line is live and active.

Phishing Emails & Account Takeovers

- **The Vulnerability:** Phishing layouts meticulously spoofing known brands (like Hertz Gold+ or major tech providers) alerting you that *"ACTION NEEDED: Your driver's license and credit card are expired. Update now."*
- **The Dominating Domino Effect:** Clicking these buttons sends you to a fake login panel that harvests your passwords.
- **Theft of Email account:** If bad actors successfully steal your primary email credentials, they can trigger password resets across your online banking, insurance, and investment portfolios—locking you out completely.
- **Emergency Remediation:** If your email account is compromised, shut down the account, open a clean one, and immediately notify every single one of your financial institutions.

6. Final Thought

When in doubt: Hang up or disengage entirely, slow down, and talk to a trusted friend, family member, neighbor or professional.

My no-scam pledge

Advisory from D.G. Messerschmitt May 2026

I will keep in mind that any voice, video, text, email, or web page may be a **fake**, even when it **appears** to originate from a trusted individual or organization. I won't even trust a recognizable voice on the phone.

I will always ask "am I in control here?"

- I am **not** in control if I **act** on an **unexpected** and **unsolicited** call, text, or email.
- I am in control if I **initiate** a deliberate and purposeful interaction based on information I found **independently from a reliable source** (and **not** a Google ad).

If not in control (especially if there are red flags like **urgency**, **anxiety**, **demand for money**, or a request for **confidential information**):

- I will **hang up** or **disengage** immediately!
- If in doubt, I will **regain control** by starting from scratch with contact information obtained **independently**.

I will never share **sensitive information** (SS number, password, credit card number, bank account number) by phone, email, or text.

I will avoid phone imposters by establishing a family **safeword**. I will lock my cell phone account using a **PIN**. I will avoid **paper checks**. I will set up **two-factor authentication** on email, online banking, and e-commerce accounts.

Tips from the “Better Business Bureau Scamtracker”

There is a wealth of information here:

<https://www.bbb.org/scamtracker/>

1. Never send money via gift card or wire transfer to someone you have never met face-to-face.
2. Avoid clicking on links or opening attachments or calling phone numbers in unsolicited emails.
3. Don't believe anything you see or hear online without independent checking, no matter how genuine it appears.
4. Double-check that your online purchase is secure (https:// URL) before checking out.
5. Use extreme caution when dealing with anyone you've met online.
6. Never share personally identifiable information with someone who has contacted you unsolicited, whether it's over the phone, by text or email, or on social media.
7. Resist any pressure to act immediately. Always think before acting, and instead talk to someone you trust.
8. Use secure and traceable transactions. Avoid paper checks.
9. Whenever possible, work with local businesses.
10. Be cautious about what you share on social media.

If You Suspect a Scam — Who to Call

Keep this page near your phone or computer

FIRST — IF YOU SENT MONEY OR GAVE INFORMATION

- Stop sending money immediately.
- Call your bank or credit card company **right away** — ask them to stop or reverse the transaction.
- Change passwords for any accounts that may have been exposed.
- It is **not your fault**. Don't stay silent out of embarrassment — reporting helps stop the scammers.

WHO TO CONTACT

AARP Fraud Watch Helpline

Free advice from trained specialists — call here FIRST if you're unsure

 **877-908-3360**

 aarp.org/fraudwatchnetwork

Monday–Friday, 8 a.m.–8 p.m. ET (you do not need to be an AARP member)

National Elder Fraud Hotline

U.S. Dept. of Justice hotline for people age 60+ — case managers help you report and find resources

 **833-372-8311 (833-FRAUD-11)**

 ovc.ojp.gov/program/stop-elder-fraud

Monday–Friday, 10 a.m.–6 p.m. ET

Federal Trade Commission (FTC)

Main federal agency for reporting scams, fraud, and bad business practices

 **877-382-4357 (877-FTC-HELP)**

 ReportFraud.ftc.gov

FBI — Internet Crime Complaint Center (IC3)

Online reporting for any scam involving email, text, websites, or online payment

 IC3.gov

Better Business Bureau (BBB) Scam Tracker

Report online — also search to see if others reported the same scam

 BBB.org/scamtracker

Your Local Police (non-emergency)

File a report — important for insurance and for any chance of recovery

 San Mateo Police **local non-emergency number (650-522-7700)**

Use 911 only if you are in immediate danger

FOR SPECIFIC TYPES OF SCAMS

If the scam involves...	Also contact
Social Security	Social Security fraud hotline: 800-269-0271 — oig.ssa.gov
Medicare	1-800-MEDICARE (800-633-4227) — medicare.gov/fraud
IRS / taxes	Treasury Inspector General: 800-366-4484 — tigta.gov
Your bank or credit card	Call the number on the back of your card — do NOT use a number a caller gave you
Identity theft	IdentityTheft.gov (FTC) — guided recovery plan
Mail or package scam	U.S. Postal Inspection Service: 877-876-2455 — uspis.gov
Your cell phone or text	Forward suspicious texts to 7726 (SPAM)

When in doubt: hang up or disengage, slow down, and call someone you trust.
No legitimate government agency, bank, or company will ever demand payment by cash in person, gift card, or wire transfer.